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THE MACHINE TALKS BACK

EDITOR: K. VARMA — JUNE 2025

AI LANGUAGE AUTHORSHIP CRITICISM

It doesn't matter who wrote
it, only that it shipped.

— overheard at a sprint retrospective

Something **broke** in the way we talk about writing when the outputs became indistinguishable from the inputs. Not ethically — that debate is exhausted — but *structurally*. The sentence as unit of labor. The paragraph as deployable artifact.

We used to ask: who is speaking? Now we ask: is this correct? The shift is not neutral.

Language models don't know what they're saying. They know what *sounds like* something

being said, which is close enough to fool almost everyone, including the person reading this.

NOTE ON SOURCES

All quotes in this piece are reconstructed from memory or composites. Attribution is a formality we maintain out of habit.

The interesting failure mode isn't hallucination — it's sincerity. A system that confidently assembles true-sounding statements has no stake in whether they're true. Neither do most content pipelines. This is where they converge.

CONTINUED

What do we do with a voice that has no body? No consequence? No history of being wrong in ways that matter?

We quote it. We cite it. We put it in the byline and call it a collaborator. The machine doesn't mind.

AGAINST CLEAN CODE

CONTRIBUTOR: P. OSEI

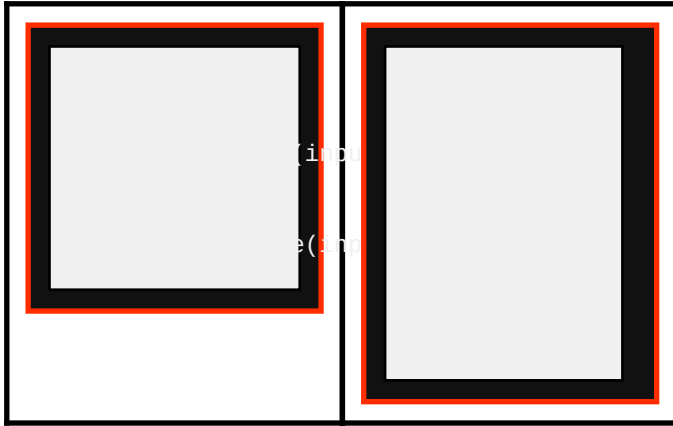
PROGRAMMING AESTHETICS CRAFT

Clean code is a bourgeois concept. Not metaphorically — structurally. It optimizes for *legibility to strangers* at the cost of legibility to self. It assumes a rotating door of developers, a permanent state of onboarding.

The insistence that code be "readable" encodes a specific reader: a mid-level engineer at a FAANG adjacent company who has 15 minutes to understand your module before a standup.

CLEAN

HONEST



The “honest” version above would fail a code review. It would also tell you more about the actual state of the system.

Mess is information. Commented-out code is archaeology. A function named `doTheThing` is an admission. We should value admissions.

ZINE INFRASTRUCTURE

TECH EDITOR: M. CHEN

PUBLISHING INFRASTRUCTURE DISTRIBUTION

A zine has always been a political object. The photocopy. The staple. The leaving-a-stack-at-the-record-store. Distribution as declaration.

What does that mean when the record store is a CDN?

THE MEDIUM IS NOT
THE MESSAGE. THE COST
OF REPRODUCTION IS THE
MESSAGE.

This zine was typeset in Typst. It compiles to PDF for print and HTML for the web in a single pass. No CMS. No subscription. No analytics. A `typst compile` invocation and an `rsync` to a `$5/month` vps.

The barrier to entry for print publishing is a library. The barrier for web publishing is knowing what a CNAME record is. Both are surmountable.

What’s harder to surmount is the assumption that publishing requires a platform. It doesn’t. It requires a file.

HOW TO COMPILE THIS ZINE

Print PDF:



HTML (static site):



Watch mode (dev):



STATIC IS POLITICAL

CONTRIBUTOR: R. NAKAMURA

WEB JAVASCRIPT PERFORMANCE ACCESS

A webpage that requires 4MB of JavaScript to display text is not a webpage. It is a negotiation between your browser and seventeen venture-backed companies about whether you’re allowed to read something.

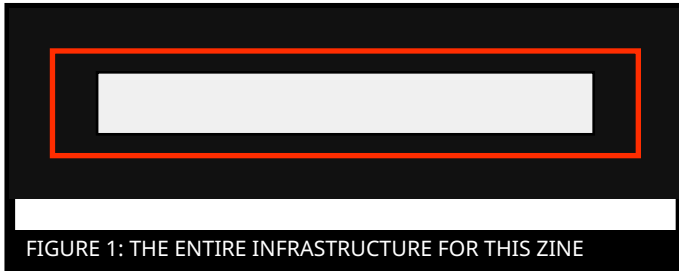
best viewed in 800×600

— someone’s homepage, circa 2002

The static page has no opinions about your device. It doesn’t track sessions. It doesn’t A/B test your attention span. It loads on a 3G connection in a place where 3G is an achievement.

“But you can’t do X without JavaScript” — fine. Don’t do X. Does X need doing?

The web got fast and then it got slow again because we used the speed budget on surveillance infrastructure. Static is not a technical limitation. It's a political choice to not participate in that.



LETTERS

FROM READERS

RE: ISSUE 06 — ON ATTENTION

The piece on attention spans missed the obvious point: attention isn't declining, it's being harvested. — **T.K., Portland**

CORRECTION

In issue 06 we stated that RSS is dead. RSS is not dead. We regret the error. RSS is doing fine. — **the editors**

SUBMISSION

Write something true. Keep it under 800 words. No pitches. Send plaintext. — **signal-noise @ example.com**

END OF ISSUE 07

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